

Lab: Tracing Your Craft Lineage

Group Activity — Learning

Objective

Map the learning histories of circle members to make visible the chains of cultural transmission that brought everyone to the table, and experience the circle's learning mechanisms firsthand.

Materials

- Large sheet of paper or poster board
- Markers in multiple colors
- Sticky notes
- Your current crochet projects
- Optional: photos of crochet teachers/family members who taught you

Duration

50-60 minutes

Activity Steps

Step 1: Craft Lineage Stories (15 minutes)

Go around the circle. Each person tells the story of how they learned to crochet: - **Who taught you?** (A grandmother, a friend, YouTube, a book, self-taught?) - **What was the first thing you learned?** (Chain, single crochet, granny square?) - **What was the most important thing your teacher passed on** — beyond just the stitches? (Patience, creativity, the joy of making?) - **How has your crochet evolved since then?** (What have you added, changed, or lost from what you were taught?)

Listen for the chains of transmission: Who taught your teacher? How far back can you trace the lineage?

Step 2: Draw the Transmission Map (10 minutes)

On the large paper, create a visual map of the circle's collective craft lineage: - Place each member's name in a circle. - Draw arrows from their teacher(s) to them. (If a grandmother taught you, write "Grandmother" and draw an arrow.) - Add the internet, books, or other sources as nodes if they were important teachers. - Use different colors for different types of transmission: family (one color), friends (another), community/class (another), self-taught/internet (another).

Look at the completed map: - How many distinct lineages converge in this one circle? - Are there common ancestors (YouTube channels, popular books, cultural traditions)? - Where does the lineage become uncertain or disappear?

Step 3: Peripheral Participation Exercise (10 minutes)

Deliberately recreate the experience of a newcomer. One person volunteers to learn something new by starting at the periphery:

1. First 3 minutes: The volunteer only **watches** the rest of the group stitch. No questions allowed. Just observe.
2. Next 3 minutes: The volunteer can **ask questions** but does not try the technique yet.
3. Final 4 minutes: The volunteer **attempts** the technique with the group's support.

After the exercise, the volunteer shares: - What did you learn from watching alone? What predictions did you form? - How did asking questions change your model? - When you finally tried it, what surprised you? Where were your prediction errors?

Step 4: The Living Library (10 minutes)

Each person writes on a sticky note one technique, tip, or piece of craft knowledge they carry that they would hate to see lost. Examples: - "My grandmother's way of joining squares with a slip stitch that lies perfectly flat" - "A trick for maintaining even tension when switching between regular and tall stitches" - "How to read old-style crochet notation from the 1970s"

Place these on the paper around the lineage map. These are the group's "endangered" generative models — knowledge that exists in only one or two people.

Discuss: - How could the circle ensure these techniques are transmitted to at least one other person? - What would it take to formalize this transmission (a "technique swap" session, a written record, a video)? - Has the circle already lost knowledge because someone left before sharing it?

Reflection Prompts

- Were you surprised by the diversity of learning paths in the group?
- How does knowing someone's craft lineage change how you understand their crochet style?
- What knowledge in the circle is at risk of being lost? What will you do about it?
- How does the circle compare to the internet as a vehicle for cultural transmission?

Extension

Start a "Technique Swap" tradition: each meeting, one member teaches one specific technique that is part of their lineage. Document it (written or video). Over time, this builds a living archive of the circle's collective generative model — ensuring that knowledge survives even as individuals come and go.